



Showers 62/46 • Tomorrow: Sunshine 58/35 **B20**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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ASGHAR BESHARATI/AP

The sun rises behind tankers in the Strait of Hormuz on Saturday. India said it summoned Iran's envoy concerning “a shooting incident” involving two Indian-flagged ships.

Global oil shock leaves cracks that threaten lasting damage

BY EVAN HALPER

As stocks soared this past week and oil prices dropped amid an apparent cooling of tensions between the United States and Iran, it may have left the impression that the energy shock that rattled the world would quickly fade, along with the risk of sending the global economy into recession. The optimism may have been short-lived. On Saturday, Iran's military announced it would reimpose restrictions on the Strait of Hormuz, throwing the critical waterway's status into doubt. The uncertainty highlights that beneath that surface, a starkly different reality is unfolding. It is defined by disrupted supply lines and damaged infrastructure, sparking increased concern

among the people who produce, transport and depend on energy. “The people closest to the industry are far more concerned about these disruptions and recognize the length of time it will take for things to return to normal — if they ever do,” said Gerry Morton, oil and gas co-chair at the law firm Baker Botts. “The further away you get from actually being involved in producing oil, the less you seem to be concerned about the physical reality and problems that are there.” Even investors rushing to tap into market optimism warned in interviews that it masks deep, underlying problems that threaten a reckoning in the not too distant future. “We know supply chains are

SEE **ECONOMY** ON **A15**

Beijing watches warily behind scenes

BY MICHELLE YE HEE LEE AND RUDY LU

China said relatively little in the early weeks of the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran, a longtime friend of Beijing. There was no outpouring of grief for the supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed. In response to the selection of his son, Mojtaba, as his successor, China's Foreign Ministry responded with a simple statement that it had “noted relevant reports.” Watching warily, Beijing has tried to position itself as a peace-maker of sorts — but also to maintain distance from the war in a region where it has minimal military influence. The cautious effort underscores China's delicate diplomacy as it seeks to avoid any tension with Washing-

Little incentive to press Iran or annoy the U.S. amid delicate diplomacy

ton while also wanting to present itself as a responsible major power, analysts said. For Beijing, economic and energy concerns are top of mind, and there is little incentive to get overly involved as President Donald Trump risks America's reputation by pursuing a war that has disrupted supply chains and sent oil prices soaring. China nonetheless didn't mince words this past week when it slammed the U.S. naval blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, calling it a “dangerous and irresponsible move.”

SEE **CHINA** ON **A12**

Hormuz is closed again, Iran says

U.S. BLOCKADE CITED; VESSELS FIRED UPON

“They can't blackmail us,” Trump says as talks go on

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE

Iran's military announced Saturday that it was closing the Strait of Hormuz, citing a continued American blockade, leaving the status of access to a vital waterway unclear a day after President Donald Trump and the country declared it open. Two ships reported attacks while attempting to cross the strait, underscoring the fragility of the ceasefire amid diplomatic efforts to end the war. Trump told reporters Saturday that the United States remained engaged in “very good conversations” with Iran and acknowledged that Tehran “wanted to close up the strait again.” “They can't blackmail us,” Trump said of Iran, adding that he would have more information on the talks with Tehran “by end of day.” Two gunboats affiliated with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps opened fire on a tanker about 20 nautical miles northeast of Oman on Saturday morning, according to the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Center (UKMTO), a monitoring agency that is part of the British Royal Navy. The agency said all crew members were reported safe. The incident was also reported by ship tracking firm TankerTrackers.com, which said a crew member aboard the tanker radioed Iran's military for help as it was under attack. In the distress call, the crew member claims the tanker had been given permission to cross the strait and asks Iran to allow the tanker to turn back, according to the report. India's External Affairs Ministry released a statement saying it had summoned Iran's ambassador in New Delhi on Saturday night, conveying concerns over what the ministry called “a shooting incident” involving two Indian-flagged ships in the strait. India's foreign secretary, the state-

SEE **IRAN** ON **A14**

A growing movement warns AI could turn on humans

BY NITASHA TIKU

On an AstroTurf lawn in Berkeley, California, one recent Friday, content creators used to making videos about romance novels, climate change and tech tips got advice on covering a more theoretical topic: How to spread the message that rogue artificial intelligence could wipe out humankind. The gathering was held at a sprawling event space popular with a Bay Area community focused on the possibility that superintelligent AI might lead to human extinction — a cause sometimes dubbed AI safety. The crowd hooted as Jeffrey Ladish, an affable former security engineer at the AI start-up Anthropic, glided to the stage on inline skates, sporting a muscle tank and mane of golden hair, to join a panel of experts in the art of talking to regular people about AI

SEE **AI** ON **A5**



ALLISON ROBERT/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Mental health measures

President Donald Trump signs an executive order Saturday instructing agencies to boost research into psychedelics such as LSD, psilocybin and ibogaine, flanked by military veterans who said the decision would save lives. Podcaster Joe Rogan, in background, also pushed for the move. **Story, A3**

D.C. police backed off on Mills arrest, files reveal

Woman recanted claim of assault after speaking to him, footage suggests

BY PAUL SCHWARTZMAN AND KADIA GOBA

D.C. police were about to arrest Rep. Cory Mills (R-Florida) after a woman accused him of assault last year, but a lieutenant ordered them not to when she changed her account after appearing to talk to the congressman, according to body-camera footage and documents obtained by The Washington Post. The next day, police reversed course, asking then-interim U.S. Attorney Ed Martin, an appointee of President Donald Trump, to sign off on a warrant to arrest Mills, a request the prosecutor denied. The Feb. 19, 2025 incident is part of a broad House Ethics

Committee investigation into Mills, now seeking a third term with Trump's endorsement. The body-camera footage and documents show that Richard Mazloom, the police officer who first responded to the accuser's 911 call, disagreed with his superior's decision to classify the incident as a “family disturbance” after the woman recanted and said Mills had not assaulted her. “Unfortunately, I have bosses that are making this into a family disturbance — a domestic disturbance — instead of an actual domestic assault,” Mazloom told the alleged victim, according to the body-camera footage that a judge ordered released to The Post last month. Before changing her account, the woman had shown Mazloom bruises on her arms and marks on her face, the body-camera

SEE **MILLS** ON **A2**

Assault allegations: A push for new Congress conduct rules. **B13**

POLITICS & THE NATION

The \$6 billion TV merger of Nexstar and Tegna is blocked for now. **A3**

SPORTS

Trump officials advocate Teddy Roosevelt for Pro Football Hall of Fame. **B1**



ARTS & STYLE

An exhibition of Raphael, the master of serenity, is a balm for the soul.

BUSINESS

Computer science, a hot college pick for 15 years, has run into a wall. **B7**



THE REGION

Justin Fairfax felt like a victim in his scandal. His family paid the price. **B13**

TRAVEL

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COMICS.....INSERT
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A17
WEATHER.....B20

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